UPSC CIVIL SERVICES MAINS | ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL | PAPER I

Topic 7 — Part B
Verbal and Non-verbal Communication; Social Context of Language Use

Exact syllabus wording covered: "Culture, language and communication: ... verbal and non-verbal communication; social context of language use."

THE OPENING STORY

In 1962 a young linguist, William Labov, walked through three New York department stores asking staff a question he already knew the answer to: "*Excuse me, where are the women's shoes?*" The answer was always "*Fourth floor.*" He wasn't interested in shoes. He was listening for the *r* in "fourth" and "floor". At upmarket Saks most staff pronounced it; at middle-market Macy's fewer did; at cheap S. Klein few did. **The same city, the same words — and a single consonant tracked social class.** That is the social context of language use in one experiment.

What this topic is really about. 7-A asked what language is. 7-B asks how people **actually communicate** — with words and without them — and how **who you are, whom you speak to, and where** shapes what you say and how it is judged. It covers the channels of non-verbal communication (gesture, space, touch, time, voice), the ethnography of speaking, and sociolinguistics: variation by class, caste, gender and region, code-switching, diglossia, and the way speech both **reflects and reproduces inequality**.

Study window	Opens 11 Nov 2026 — **half a day** (one session), per your Subject Coverage row
Estimated study time	2 hr first pass, including the 20-mark inequality answer
Revision time	15 min full note • 5 min one-page sheet (Section 15)
Study as	Three units — **non-verbal channels**, **language in social context** (Malinowski → Hymes → Gumperz), and **language and inequality** (Labov, Bernstein, Bourdieu, India). Learn Fig. 1 and Fig. 3 cold.
Note status	Draft 1 — for your review. Not final until you sign it off.
Boundary	Definition, design features, origin and Sapir–Whorf are **7-A** (done). Field methods are **Topic 8**. Linguistic states and language movements are **Paper II**.

Candid verdict — few askings, but one of them is a 20-marker. Three stems fall in 7-B: **2017** (non-verbal communication, note, 10), **2020** (variation in language use and social inequality, 20) and **2021** (branches of linguistic anthropology and language use in social and cultural settings, 15). None in 2022–2026. Your tracker shows PYQ Count 5 and Mains Value **Low**; on three askings worth 45 marks across five years, I have set it to **Medium**. The inequality question is the one to over-prepare: it is the only 20-marker, and it links straight to caste, tribe and education in Paper II.

2 SCOPE MAP

What is included

- **Communication** — the model, verbal and non-verbal, and Malinowski's phatic communion.

- **Non-verbal channels** — kinesics, proxemics, paralanguage, haptics, chronemics, oculesics, artefacts and silence; Ekman's universals and display rules; whistled and drummed speech; sign languages.
- **Social context of language use** — context of situation, speech acts, ethnography of speaking (SPEAKING), communicative competence, speech community.
- **Sociolinguistics** — variation by class, caste, gender, age and region; register; diglossia; code-switching; pidgins and creoles; honorifics.
- **Language and inequality** — Labov, Bernstein, Bourdieu, language ideology; Indian cases.
- **Branches of linguistic anthropology** — the 2021 question; Duranti's three paradigms.

What is excluded, and where it belongs

Material	Belongs to	Why it is kept out
Nature, design features, origin; Sapir–Whorf	7-A, done	Language as system and capacity — a different revision logic
Participant observation, interviews	Topic 8	Methods; language as a tool is named only
Linguistic reorganisation of states; language movements	Paper II	Political use of language
Caste and stratification theory	3 / Paper II	Used here only as the social side of variation

How it connects outward

- **7-A** — Chomsky's competence is what Hymes widened into communicative competence; the 2025 culture–language–thought question straddles both parts.
- **6-H** — Geertz's wink and twitch: the same eyelid movement, different meaning by context — non-verbal communication as culture.
- **6-J** — language ideology and Bourdieu's symbolic power feed the postmodern critique of authority.
- **Paper II** — tribal languages and schooling, Article 350A, Eighth Schedule, caste and speech.

3 PYQ DEMAND AUDIT

Mains

Wording and marks from your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 7); 2022–2026 checked against full papers (no 7-B stem).

Year	Question (as recorded)	Demand	Marks
2021	Mention the major branches of linguistic anthropology and discuss language use in social and cultural settings.	Branches + ethnography of speaking + sociolinguistics	15
2020	Explain how variations in language usage [are] related to social inequality.	Labov, Bernstein, Bourdieu; caste, gender; India	20
2017	Non-verbal communication (note, 150 words).	Channels with scholars and examples	10

Prelims

Not applicable. The optional is a Mains paper; GS Prelims has not tested this content.

What UPSC is actually testing

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
Language and inequality	1 — 2020	That variation is patterned, evaluated and consequential — with a mechanism, not only examples	5.5 + Fig. 3. Master Answer 1

Demand	Times	What is really being tested	Your reading
Language in social settings; branches	1 — 2021	The sub-fields, then Malinowski, Hymes, Gumperz with cases	5.4, 5.6. Master Answer 2
Non-verbal communication	1 — 2017	Named channels, scholars and cross-cultural variation	5.2–5.3 + Fig. 1–2. Master Answer 3

Trend reading

- **Three askings in five years (2017–2021), then silence.** A return is likely as a 10-mark note — code-switching, diglossia, ethnography of speaking, or proxemics.
- **Inequality is the heavy strand.** If a 15–20-marker returns, expect a social-justice framing like 6-J's 2025 stem. Carry Indian cases.
- **Mains Value: Medium.** Three askings, 45 marks.

4 BIG-PICTURE CONCEPTUAL MAP

MOVE 1 — Communication is more than words. Verbal language carries content; non-verbal channels — body, space, touch, time, voice — carry relationship, emotion and status, and often contradict the words.

MOVE 2 — Non-verbal signals are partly universal, mostly cultural. Basic facial expressions are recognised widely (Ekman); gestures, distances, touch and timing are learnt and vary (Birdwhistell, Hall). *Fig. 1, Fig. 2*

MOVE 3 — Meaning depends on context. Malinowski's context of situation, Austin's speech acts, Hymes's ethnography of speaking: knowing a language means knowing **when, to whom and how** to say what — communicative competence.

MOVE 4 — Speech varies systematically. By class, caste, gender, age, region and setting; people switch codes and registers; some societies keep high and low varieties (diglossia).

MOVE 5 — Variation becomes inequality. Some varieties are valued and others stigmatised; schools, jobs and courts reward the valued one, so speech reproduces hierarchy (Bernstein, Bourdieu) — though the stigmatised varieties are no less logical (Labov). *Fig. 3*

That chain is the shape of any answer: **channels → universal and cultural → context → variation → inequality.**

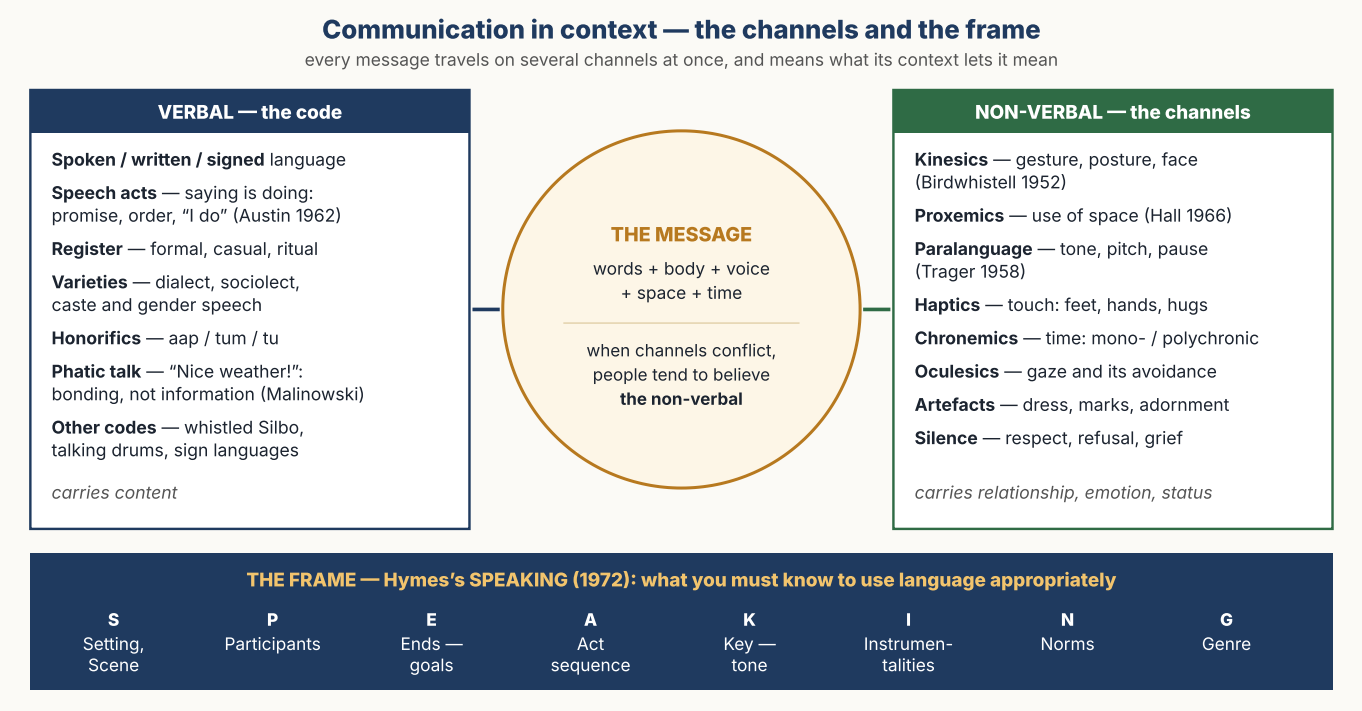


Fig. 1 — the hero diagram. Verbal and non-verbal channels feed one message; Hymes's SPEAKING grid is the context that decides what the message means. Draw the two columns and the SPEAKING bar for any 7-B answer.

5 CORE NOTES

5.1 What communication is — and why small talk matters

STORY HOOK

*"Nice weather today!" tells nobody anything they do not know — yet walking past a neighbour in silence would be an insult. Malinowski (1923) called such talk **phatic communion**: words used to create a bond, not to carry information.*

Why it helps: it shows at once that language does social work, not only informational work.

- **Definition.** Communication is the transmission of meaning between individuals through shared symbols and signals, verbal and non-verbal, within a cultural context.
- **The basic model.** Sender → message encoded in a code → channel → receiver decodes → feedback, with "noise". Anthropology adds that sender and receiver share, or fail to share, cultural codes.
- **Verbal communication** uses language — spoken, written or signed — and carries propositional content.
- **Non-verbal communication** uses body, voice quality, space, touch, time and objects; it carries relationship, emotion and status, and frames how words are taken.
- **Malinowski, "The Problem of Meaning in Primitive Languages" (1923):** meaning depends on the **context of situation**; language is a "mode of action", not only a "countersign of thought".

5.2 Non-verbal communication — the channels (the 2017 question)

STORY HOOK

In the 1950s Edward T. Hall trained American diplomats. He kept seeing the same dance: a Latin American colleague stepped closer to talk; the American stepped back; the colleague stepped closer again — until the American was pinned against a wall, sure the other man was pushy, while the other man was sure the American was cold.

Why it helps: proxemics — culturally learnt distance — in one scene.

Channel	What it covers	Scholar / example
Kinesics	Gesture, posture, facial movement, head movement — "body language"	Ray Birdwhistell coined it (1952); *Kinesics and Context* 1970
Proxemics	Use of space: intimate, personal, social, public distance	Edward T. Hall, *The Silent Language* 1959; *The Hidden Dimension* 1966
Paralanguage	How something is said: pitch, loudness, tempo, pause, laughter, sighs	George Trager 1958
Haptics	Touch — who may touch whom, where, when	Touching elders' feet; handshake vs *namaste*
Chronemics	Use of time — punctuality, waiting, pace	Hall: **monochronic** (one thing at a time) vs **polychronic** (many at once)
Oculesics	Eye contact and its avoidance	Direct gaze as honesty in some cultures, as disrespect to elders in others
Artefacts and adornment	Dress, marks, ornaments, hairstyle as messages	*Sindoor*, sacred thread, tribal tattoos and dormitory dress
Silence	Pause, refusal, respect, mourning	Western Apache silence with strangers (Basso 1970)

Ekman and Friesen's five functions (1969)

Emblems (gestures with a direct verbal translation — thumbs-up, *namaste*); **illustrators** (gestures that accompany speech); **affect displays** (facial emotion); **regulators** (nods and glances that manage turn-taking); **adaptors** (self-

touching, fidgeting).

5.3 Universal or cultural? — the face and the head-shake

> **STORY HOOK**
> *In the late 1960s Paul Ekman took photographs of American faces to the Fore of Papua New Guinea, a people with almost no contact with outsiders, and asked them to match faces to stories. They picked out happiness, sadness, anger and disgust much as Americans did — but often confused fear and surprise.*
> Why it helps: one study gives you both the universal and its limits.

- **The universalist case.** Darwin, *The Expression of the Emotions in Man and Animals* (1872); Ekman & Friesen (1971): six basic expressions — happiness, sadness, anger, fear, surprise, disgust — widely recognised.
- **The cultural case.** Birdwhistell argued that no gesture has the same meaning everywhere. **Display rules** (Ekman's own term) govern when emotions may be shown: Japanese students masked disgust in front of an experimenter where Americans did not.
- **Emblems are cultural.** The Indian head-tilt (agreement), the Bulgarian nod (no), the thumbs-up (praise in some places, insult in others).
- **The balanced view.** A small biological core of affect displays, with culture deciding **when, how much and to whom** they are shown; most gestures, distances and touch rules are learnt.
- **A caution.** The popular "7 per cent words, 38 per cent voice, 55 per cent body" rule comes from Albert Mehrabian's small experiments (1967) on liking, not on all communication. Do not quote it as a general law.

Hall's proxemic zones

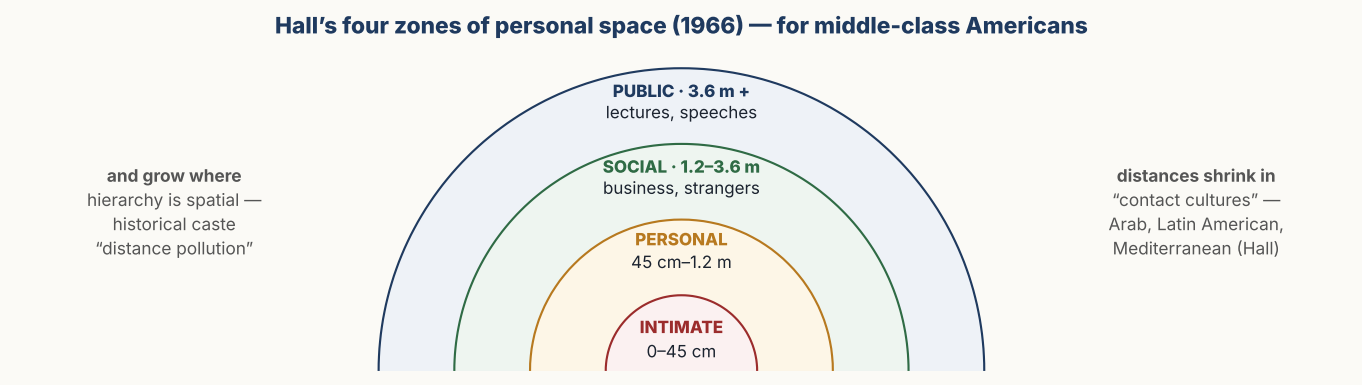


Fig. 2 — Hall's proxemic zones. The distances are Hall's figures for one culture; the anthropological point is that they vary. In India, caste rules once fixed physical distance itself — the historical "distance pollution" of Kerala.

Other channels worth one line

- **Whistled speech.** On La Gomera in the Canary Islands, **Silbo Gomero** whistles Spanish across ravines; UNESCO listed it as intangible heritage in 2009.
- **Drum languages.** West African talking drums reproduce the tones of speech.
- **Sign languages** are full languages, not gesture. India set up the Indian Sign Language Research and Training Centre in 2015.

5.4 Language in social context

> **STORY HOOK**
> *When a bride and groom say **"I do"**, they are not describing a marriage — they are making one. J. L. Austin (1962) called such utterances **performatives**: words that do things.*
> Why it helps: speech-act theory, and the whole idea that language is action, in two words.

- **Context of situation** — Malinowski (1923): Trobriand fishing talk makes sense only inside the activity.
- **Speech acts** — Austin, *How to Do Things with Words* (1962); Searle (1969): promising, ordering, blessing, cursing, naming.

- **Ethnography of speaking / communication** — Dell Hymes (1962, 1964): study when, where, by whom and how speech is used; his **SPEAKING** grid (1972) lists Setting, Participants, Ends, Act sequence, Key, Instrumentalities, Norms and Genre. MEMORISE
- **Communicative competence** — Hymes (1966/1972) against Chomsky: knowing a language is knowing not only grammar but **what to say to whom, when and how**.
- **Speech community** — Gumperz: a group sharing rules for the use and interpretation of speech, not only a grammar.
- **Register** — the variety used for a setting: ritual Sanskrit at a wedding, office English, kitchen Telugu.
- **Code-switching** — moving between languages or varieties within one conversation. Blom & Gumperz (1972) in Hemnesberget, Norway: locals switched from dialect to standard when talk turned official. In India: Hindi–English "Hinglish", Telugu–English in Hyderabad offices.
- **Diglossia** — Charles Ferguson (1959): a "high" variety for formal, written and religious use, and a "low" one for daily speech — Arabic, Swiss German, Greek; in India, **literary and spoken Tamil**.
- **Pidgins and creoles** — contact languages; a pidgin has no native speakers, a creole is a pidgin learnt by children as a first language (Nagamese in Nagaland is a widely cited Indian case).
- **Honorifics** — grammar that encodes status: Hindi *aap/tum/tu*, Telugu *meeru/nuvvu*, Javanese speech levels (Geertz, *The Religion of Java*, 1960).

5.5 Variation and social inequality — the 2020 question

STORY HOOK

In the 1950s John Gumperz lived in Khalapur, a village in Uttar Pradesh. Everyone spoke "the village dialect" — yet he found that castes spoke measurably different versions of it, and the sharpest differences ran between touchable and untouchable castes.

Why it helps: the Indian proof that language variation maps onto social hierarchy.

The patterns

- **Class** — Labov, *The Social Stratification of English in New York City* (1966); the department-store study (the opening story). Speakers also shift towards the prestige form when careful — **style shifting**.
- **Caste** — Gumperz, "Dialect Differences and Social Stratification in a North Indian Village" (*American Anthropologist*, 1958); Bright and Ramanujan (1964) on Brahmin and non-Brahmin Kannada and Tamil.
- **Gender** — Robin Lakoff, *Language and Woman's Place* (1975): hedges, tag questions, "empty" adjectives; Deborah Tannen (1990): rapport-talk vs report-talk. Women are often more conservative with prestige forms (Trudgill). In India: name taboos for husbands and in-laws among many communities.
- **Region and ethnicity** — dialect hierarchies: standard Hindi over Bhojpuri; African American English in the US.
- **Age and setting** — youth slang; formal and informal registers.

How variation becomes inequality — the mechanisms

Mechanism	The argument	Who
Codes and schooling	Working-class children use a **restricted code** (context-bound, implicit); schools reward the middle-class **elaborated code** (explicit, universalistic)	Basil Bernstein, *Class, Codes and Control* 1971
Difference, not deficit	Stigmatised varieties are fully rule-governed and logical; the problem is prejudice, not the speech	Labov, "The Logic of Nonstandard English" 1969
Linguistic capital	Language is capital: the "legitimate" variety buys profit in the linguistic market; others are discounted	Pierre Bourdieu, *Language and Symbolic Power* 1991
Language ideology	Beliefs that one variety is "correct", "pure" or "educated" justify hierarchy among speakers	Silverstein; Irvine & Gal 2000
Gatekeeping	Interviews, courts and offices judge people by speech style; misreadings disadvantage minorities	Gumperz, *Discourse Strategies* 1982

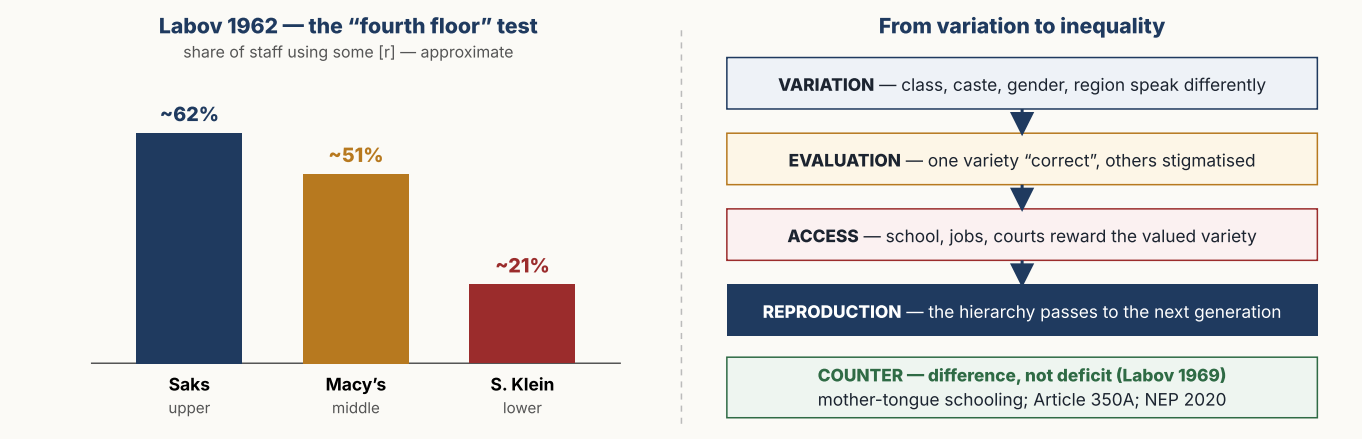


Fig. 3 — left: Labov's department-store result (figures rounded; quote them as approximate); right: the four-step chain by which variation becomes inequality, with the counter-argument and the policy fix. Draw the right half for the 2020 question.

India — the cases for the inequality answer

- **Caste and speech.** Gumperz's Khalapur (1958); Bright and Ramanujan (1964) on Brahmin and non-Brahmin dialects; Srinivas noted that Sanskritisation includes adopting "purer" speech and vocabulary.
- **English as capital.** English-medium schooling and fluency as a gateway to elite jobs — Bourdieu's linguistic capital in an Indian form.
- **Tribal languages and school.** Children taught only in a regional standard they do not speak fall behind; mother-tongue-based multilingual education (Odisha's programme in tribal languages, from the late 2000s); **Article 350A** (instruction in the mother tongue at primary stage for linguistic minorities); NEP 2020 (mother tongue "wherever possible" to Grade 5).
- **Scheduled and unscheduled.** 22 Eighth Schedule languages get official status; hundreds of tribal languages do not.
- **Gendered speech.** Husband's-name taboos; respectful speech expected of daughters-in-law (*ghunghat* as non-verbal counterpart).

5.6 The branches of linguistic anthropology — the 2021 question

Branch	What it studies	Names
Descriptive / structural linguistics	Phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics of particular languages	Boas, Sapir, Bloomfield
Historical linguistics	Language change, families, reconstruction; glottochronology	Sir William Jones 1786; Swadesh
Ethnolinguistics	Language and culture, classification, worldview	Whorf; Conklin; Frake
Sociolinguistics	Variation and social structure	Labov; Gumperz; Ferguson
Ethnography of communication	Speech events, norms of use, competence	Hymes; Gumperz

Alessandro Duranti's three paradigms (*Current Anthropology*, 2003): (1) Boasian documentation of languages; (2) ethnography of communication (Hymes, Gumperz, 1960s); (3) language as social action — identity, power and ideology (1980s on). Use it to show the field's growth in one sentence.

6 WHAT TO MEMORISE VERSUS WHAT TO UNDERSTAND

Tier	Content
MEMORISE word for word	The eight non-verbal channels with one scholar each • Hall's four zones and distances • Ekman's five functions and six basic emotions • Malinowski 1923 phatic communion and context of situation • Hymes's SPEAKING letters • Ferguson 1959 diglossia • Labov 1962/1966; Gumperz 1958; Bernstein 1971; Bourdieu 1991 • Article 350A

Tier	Content
UNDERSTAND and reproduce flexibly	Universal versus cultural in non-verbal signs • communicative vs grammatical competence • code-switching and diglossia distinguished • the four-step inequality chain • deficit vs difference • the branches and Duranti's paradigms
CONCEPTUAL recall only	Trager, Basso, Lakoff, Tannen details • Searle • Silverstein, Irvine & Gal • Silbo Gomero • Nagamese • the Mehrabian caution

7 HIGH-ROI FACTUAL ANCHORS

Item	What to remember	Why it matters	Story hook
Malinowski, 1923	Phatic communion; context of situation	Language as action	"Nice weather!"
Birdwhistell, 1952	Kinesics	Non-verbal channels	—
Hall, 1959 / 1966	Proxemics; monochronic / polychronic	2017 note	Diplomat pinned to a wall
Ekman & Friesen, 1969 / 1971	Five functions; six expressions; Fore study; display rules	Universal vs cultural	Photos in New Guinea
Austin, 1962	Speech acts; performatives	Language as action	"I do"
Hymes, 1962 / 1972	Ethnography of speaking; SPEAKING; communicative competence	2021 question	—
Ferguson, 1959	Diglossia	Tamil case	—
Blom & Gumperz, 1972	Code-switching, Hemnesberget	Social context	Dialect to standard
Gumperz, 1958	Khalapur: caste and dialect	India, inequality	Village dialects
Labov, 1962 / 1966 / 1969	Department stores; NYC stratification; logic of nonstandard English	2020 question	"Fourth floor"
Bernstein, 1971	Restricted and elaborated codes	Schooling	—
Bourdieu, 1991	Linguistic capital; symbolic power	Mechanism	—
Duranti, 2003	Three paradigms	2021 question	—

8 TECHNICAL VOCABULARY BANK

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Phatic communion	Talk for bonding, not information	Social context	"Greetings are phatic communion."
Kinesics	Meaningful body movement	2017 note	"The Indian head-tilt is a kinesic emblem of assent."
Proxemics	Cultural use of space	2017 note	"Caste distance rules were proxemics enforced by law and custom."
Paralanguage	Voice qualities beyond words	2017 note	"Sarcasm lives in paralanguage."
Display rules	Cultural rules for showing emotion	Universal vs cultural	"Display rules mask a universal expression."
Speech act	An utterance that performs an action	Social context	"A curse is a speech act."

Term	Simple meaning	Where to use it	Example sentence
Communicative competence	Knowing how to use language appropriately	Hymes	"A fluent outsider may lack communicative competence."
Speech community	People sharing norms of speaking	Gumperz	"Khalapur was one speech community with caste sub-varieties."
Register	A variety suited to a setting	Variation	"Court Hindi is a register of its own."
Code-switching	Moving between languages within talk	Social context	"Hinglish code-switching signals urban identity."
Diglossia	High and low varieties with separate functions	Variation	"Tamil shows classic diglossia."
Restricted / elaborated code	Context-bound vs explicit speech	Inequality	"Bernstein's codes explain unequal school success."
Linguistic capital	Speech as a resource that buys status	Inequality	"English is linguistic capital in India."
Language ideology	Beliefs about which speech is correct	Inequality	"Purist ideology stigmatises dialects."

9 ANSWER EXPRESSION TOOLKIT

Definitions to reproduce

- **Non-verbal communication:** the transmission of meaning without words, through body movement, facial expression, voice quality, space, touch, time and objects, largely learnt and culturally variable.
- **Communicative competence (Hymes):** the knowledge that enables a speaker to use language appropriately — what to say, to whom, when and how — in a given community.
- **Sociolinguistics:** the study of how language varies with social factors such as class, caste, gender, age and setting, and how that variation carries social meaning.

Exam-ready opening hooks

- (Inequality) "In 1962 Labov asked shop assistants for 'the fourth floor' and found that a single consonant, the r, rose and fell with the class of the store."
- (Non-verbal) "Edward Hall watched American diplomats back across rooms as Latin American colleagues stepped closer — each reading the other's distance as character, when it was culture."
- (Social context) "'Nice weather today!' conveys no information, yet silence would offend: Malinowski called such talk phatic communion."

Analytical and transition lines

- "Words carry content; the body, voice and space carry the relationship."
- "Knowing a language is knowing its grammar; using it is knowing its society."
- "Variation becomes inequality when one variety is made the price of entry to school, work and law."

Criticism and qualification lines

- "Ekman's universals concern a few basic expressions; most gestures, distances and touch rules are learnt."
- "Bernstein was read as blaming working-class speech; Labov showed nonstandard varieties are fully logical."
- "The 7–38–55 rule is a misreading of small experiments, not a law of communication."

Conclusions

- "Language is never socially neutral: how we speak places us, and how we are heard decides what we can do."
- "Mother-tongue education and respect for dialect are the policy face of Labov's 'difference, not deficit'."

India linkages

- Gumperz's Khalapur (1958) • Brahmin/non-Brahmin dialects (Bright & Ramanujan 1964) • Tamil diglossia • Hinglish • *aap/tum/tu* • touching feet, *namaste*, *ghunghat* • Kerala distance pollution • Article 350A • NEP 2020 • Nagamese • ISLRTC 2015.

10 DIAGRAM BANK

Figure	Verdict	Use it for	How to reproduce in about 30 seconds
Fig. 1 — channels and frame	HIGHEST ROI — draw it	2017, 2021; any 7-B answer	Two columns (verbal, non-verbal), a central "message", and the eight SPEAKING letters beneath
Fig. 2 — proxemic zones	Draw for non-verbal	2017 note	Four nested arcs with the four distances
Fig. 3 — inequality chain	Draw for 2020	Inequality, justice	Four stacked boxes — variation → evaluation → access → reproduction — and a green counter box

11 COMPARISONS AND DEBATES

11.1 Verbal against non-verbal communication

Basis	Verbal	Non-verbal
Carries mainly	Propositional content	Emotion, relationship, status
Structure	Discrete, rule-governed, productive	Often continuous and graded
Control	Largely deliberate	Often unconscious
Universality	All languages different, capacity universal	A few universal expressions; most cultural
Displacement	Can speak of the absent	Mostly tied to the present

11.2 Code-switching against diglossia

Basis	Code-switching	Diglossia
Level	Individual, within a conversation	Societal, between domains
Varieties	Any two languages or dialects	A "high" and a "low" variety of one language
Choice	Strategic, fluid	Fixed by function and setting
Example	Hinglish; Hemnesberget	Literary and spoken Tamil; Arabic

11.3 Bernstein against Labov

Basis	Bernstein	Labov
Claim	Restricted vs elaborated codes shape school success	Nonstandard varieties are fully logical
Read as	A deficit view (he denied it)	The difference view
Lesson	Schools reward one code	The problem is prejudice, not speech
Policy	Teach the elaborated code	Respect and build on home varieties

12 MASTER QUESTIONS AND ANSWERS

MASTER ANSWER 1 (20 marks). "Explain how variations in language usage are related to social inequality." (2020)

In 1962 William Labov asked New York shop assistants where to find goods on "the fourth floor". The share who pronounced the *r* fell from upmarket Saks to middle-market Macy's to cheap S. Klein: a single consonant tracked social class. Language varies systematically with social position, and that variation both **reflects and reproduces** inequality.

Patterns of variation. By **class**: Labov's *Social Stratification of English in New York City* (1966) showed that speakers shift towards prestige forms when careful. By **caste**: Gumperz (1958) found that castes in the Uttar Pradesh village of Khalapur spoke distinct varieties, most sharply between touchable and untouchable castes; Bright and Ramanujan (1964) contrasted Brahmin and non-Brahmin dialects in the south. By **gender**: Lakoff (1975) described a "women's language" of hedges and tag questions; in many Indian communities wives avoid uttering a husband's name. By **region and ethnicity**: standard Hindi over Bhojpuri; standard English over African American English. Honorific systems — *aap, tum, tu* — build hierarchy into grammar itself.

How variation becomes inequality. First, **evaluation**: language ideologies label one variety correct and others crude (Irvine and Gal). Second, **access**: schools, offices and courts reward the valued variety. Bernstein (1971) argued that schools prize the middle-class "elaborated code" over the working-class "restricted code"; Bourdieu (1991) called the legitimate language a form of **linguistic capital** that buys profit in the market. Third, **gatekeeping**: interviews misread minority speech styles (Gumperz 1982). Fourth, **reproduction**: the hierarchy passes to the next generation. *[Draw Fig. 3.]*

India. English-medium schooling works as elite capital; tribal children taught only in a regional standard fall behind; only 22 languages enjoy Eighth Schedule status.

Critique and remedy. Bernstein was read as a "deficit" theorist; Labov's "Logic of Nonstandard English" (1969) showed stigmatised varieties are fully rule-governed — the problem is prejudice, not speech. Remedies follow: mother-tongue instruction at the primary stage (Article 350A; NEP 2020; Odisha's multilingual education in tribal languages) and the recognition of dialects as legitimate.

Language is never neutral: how one speaks places one socially, and how one is heard decides access to opportunity.

About 390 words — right for 20 marks. The four-step mechanism is what separates a 12 from a 15+.

MASTER ANSWER 2 (15 marks). "Mention the major branches of linguistic anthropology and discuss language use in social and cultural settings." (2021)

Linguistic anthropology, one of Boas's four fields, studies language as a cultural resource and speaking as a cultural practice.

Branches. (1) **Descriptive or structural linguistics** — the sound systems, word structure and grammar of particular languages (Boas, Sapir). (2) **Historical linguistics** — families, change and reconstruction, from Sir William Jones (1786) to Swadesh's glottochronology. (3) **Ethnolinguistics** — language, classification and worldview (Whorf; Conklin). (4) **Sociolinguistics** — variation and social structure (Labov, Ferguson). (5) **Ethnography of communication** — the norms of speaking in a community (Hymes, Gumperz). Duranti (2003) traces three paradigms: documentation, ethnography of communication, and language as social action.

Language in social and cultural settings. Malinowski (1923) showed meaning depends on the **context of situation** and that much talk is **phatic communion** — bonding, not information. Austin (1962) showed that utterances such as "I do" perform acts. Hymes's **SPEAKING** grid — setting, participants, ends, act sequence, key, instrumentalities, norms, genre — and his idea of **communicative competence** capture what a speaker must know beyond grammar. *[Draw Fig. 1.]*

Speakers shift **register** by setting, **code-switch** between languages for effect (Blom and Gumperz's Norwegian case; Hinglish in Indian cities), and live with **diglossia** — high and low varieties, as in literary and spoken Tamil

(Ferguson 1959). **Honorifics** encode hierarchy, from Javanese speech levels to *aap/tum/tu*, and caste, gender and class leave their mark on speech (Gumperz's Khalapur).

Language use is thus a social map: it marks identity, enacts relationships and distributes status.

About 300 words.

MASTER ANSWER 3 (10 marks, about 150 words). "Non-verbal communication." (2017)

Non-verbal communication conveys meaning without words — through body, voice, space, touch, time and objects. Its main channels are **kinesics**, gesture and facial expression (Birdwhistell, 1952); **proxemics**, the use of space, with Hall's intimate, personal, social and public zones (1966); **paralanguage**, tone and pause (Trager); **haptics**, touch; and **chronemics**, time, where Hall contrasted monochronic and polychronic cultures. Gaze, dress and silence also speak.

Ekman and Friesen found six basic facial expressions recognised even by the isolated Fore of New Guinea, but cultural **display rules** govern their use, and most gestures are learnt: the Indian head-tilt signals assent, touching elders' feet shows respect, and caste distance rules once fixed physical space itself. Non-verbal cues carry emotion and status, and where they contradict words, they are usually believed.

About 150 words. One Indian example per channel is the easy lift.

13 MAINS QUESTION BANK

#	Question	Marks	Tags
1	Non-verbal communication.	10	H R D S I
2	Proxemics.	10	D S
3	Code-switching.	10	S I
4	Diglossia.	10	S I
5	Ethnography of speaking.	10	R D S
6	Communicative competence.	10	S
7	Mention the major branches of linguistic anthropology and discuss language use in social and cultural settings.	15	H R D S
8	Are non-verbal signals universal or cultural? Discuss with examples.	15	S I
9	Explain how variations in language usage are related to social inequality.	20	H R D S I
10	Discuss the role of language in caste and gender hierarchies in India.	15	I
11	Examine the relevance of mother-tongue education for tribal communities.	15	I
12	"Language is a form of symbolic power." Discuss.	15	S

H = asked or near-verbatim • R = high ROI • D = needs a diagram • S = needs a scholar or case • I = needs an India linkage.

14 CLOSED-BOOK RECALL DRILL

Core concepts (5)
- Define non-verbal communication and name eight channels.
- Hall's four zones with distances.
- Ekman's five functions; six basic expressions; display rules.
- Hymes's SPEAKING — all eight letters.
- Communicative vs grammatical competence.

Factual anchors (5)
- Labov's three stores and what they showed.
- Gumperz's Khalapur finding.

Comparisons (3)
- Verbal vs non-verbal on five bases.
- Code-switching vs diglossia.
- Bernstein vs Labov.

Critical judgement (2)
- The four-step chain from variation to inequality.
- Why the 7–38–55 rule should not be quoted.

Diagram reproduction (2)
- Draw Fig. 1 with the SPEAKING bar.

- Ferguson's diglossia with two cases.
- Bernstein's two codes; Labov's reply.
- Article 350A and NEP 2020 in one line each.

- Draw Fig. 3's chain with the counter box.

Story recall (1)

- Tell each hook in one line: fourth floor, nice weather, the diplomat and the wall, photos in New Guinea, "I do", Khalapur.

15 ONE-PAGE QUICK-REVISION SHEET

THE SPINE

Channels — verbal carries content; non-verbal (kinesics, proxemics, paralanguage, haptics, chronemics, gaze, artefacts, silence) carries relationship → **universal and cultural** — six basic expressions (Ekman), display rules and learnt gestures and distances (Birdwhistell, Hall) → **context** — Malinowski 1923, Austin 1962, Hymes's SPEAKING and communicative competence → **variation** — class, caste, gender, region; register, code-switching, diglossia, honorifics → **inequality** — evaluation, access, reproduction (Bernstein, Bourdieu); difference not deficit (Labov); mother-tongue schooling.

ESSENTIAL TERMS

phatic communion • context of situation • kinesics • proxemics • paralanguage • haptics • chronemics • display rules • emblem • speech act • communicative competence • speech community • register • code-switching • diglossia • pidgin/creole • restricted/elaborated code • linguistic capital • language ideology

STORY HOOKS

Labov's "fourth floor" • "Nice weather!" • Hall's diplomat pinned to the wall • Ekman's photos among the Fore • "I do" • Hemnesberget switch • Khalapur castes • Silbo Gomero • Kerala distance rules

ESSENTIAL SCHOLARS

Darwin 1872 • Malinowski 1923 • Birdwhistell 1952 • Trager 1958 • Hall 1959/66 • Gumperz 1958/82 • Ferguson 1959 • Austin 1962 • Hymes 1962/72 • Labov 1966/69 • Ekman & Friesen 1969/71 • Bernstein 1971 • Blom & Gumperz 1972 • Lakoff 1975 • Bourdieu 1991 • Duranti 2003

THE THREE LINES TO HAVE WORD-PERFECT

- 1. Words carry content; the body, voice and space carry the relationship.
- 2. Knowing a language is knowing its grammar; using it is knowing its society. (Hymes's communicative competence)
- 3. Variation becomes inequality when one variety is made the price of entry to school, work and law.

DIAGRAM CUES

Fig. 1 verbal | message | non-verbal over the SPEAKING bar • Fig. 2 four arcs: 45 cm, 1.2 m, 3.6 m • Fig. 3 variation → evaluation → access → reproduction, counter in green.

CONFUSIONS TO AVOID

- Code-switching (individual, fluid) ≠ diglossia (societal, fixed by domain).
- Ekman's universals cover a few expressions only — not gestures.
- Do not quote 7–38–55 as a law.
- Bernstein is not simply a "deficit" theorist; say he was *read* as one.

16 SOURCES AND HONEST CAVEATS

What this note was built from

- **UPSC syllabus** — Paper I, clause 7 (second part).
- **PYQs** — your 1995–2021 compilation (Vishnu IAS, Unit 7): 2017, 2020, 2021; Edukemy 2013–2023 list; 2024–2026 papers (no 7-B stem).
- **Standard sources** — Malinowski (1923); Birdwhistell (1952, 1970); Trager (1958); Hall (1959, 1966); Ferguson (1959); Austin (1962); Hymes (1962, 1972); Gumperz (1958, 1982); Blom & Gumperz (1972); Labov (1966, 1969); Ekman & Friesen (1969, 1971); Bernstein (1971); Lakoff (1975); Bourdieu (1991); Duranti (2003).

Where you should be careful

- **The 2021 stem** straddles 7-A and 7-B; I count it in 7-B. The 2019 relationship question I count in 7-A.
- **Mains Value.** Your tracker had PYQ Count 5 and Low; I count three and set Medium.

- **Labov's percentages** are rounded and differ slightly by how "some r" is counted; write "roughly six in ten at Saks, five at Macy's, two at Klein's".
- **Gumperz's Khalapur** finding is given in summary; the touchable/untouchable contrast is the safe headline.
- **Hall's distances** describe one culture; present them as an illustration of variation, not a universal.
- **Odisha's multilingual education programme** is described generally ("from the late 2000s, in tribal languages"); avoid exact numbers in the exam.